to the Aravalli ridges, the oldest discernible geological feature on this planet. If you look north from one of Gurgaon's tall office blocks, you will see the Qutub Minar, built by a Turkish slave-general to commemorate the conquest of Delhi. Just below the medieval tower, globalized Indians enjoy Thai and Italian food at the expensive restaurants of Mehrauli, an urban village that is steadily gentrifying. Metro trains slither nearby on their elevated tracks.

Similarly, a short drive south of the imperial inscriptions of Junagarh, the Asiatic lion is making a slow comeback. A survey in 2010 suggests that there are now 411 lions in Gir. In fact, the sanctuary in Gir is proving to be too small for the expanded population and some of these animals are now wandering into the surrounding countryside. Some have even been seen on the beaches of Kodinar. Just across from this beach is the island of Diu, a Portuguese stronghold for four centuries. At some point, the Portuguese had presented a group of African slaves to the Nawab of Junagarh. Their direct descendants now live in hamlets just outside Gir National Park. Thus, the country's bubbling genetic mix has come to include a barely-remembered community of African Indians! The Sidi community of Sasan Gir is nominally Muslim but retains customs, music and dances from its African past.

The last hundred years have not been kind to India's tigers. It is estimated that barely 1706 of them remain in the wild, down from over 3600 in the 1990s. Poaching is a major problem but even more important is the destruction of their habitat through illegal encroachments, logging and mining. The imagery of the lion and the tiger, however, remains alive in the human mind. Every year, the drums of Kolkata beat for Goddess Durga, astride her lion, at war with Evil. In Singapore, tourists take snaps of the Merlion, half-lion and half-mermaid, a mythical beast that through many twists and turns recalls the influence of ancient Indian merchants who brought their culture to these distant shores. These distant cultural memories can have very important symbolic meaning for modern people. In 2009, the Sri Lankan army, flying a lion flag, decimated the separatist Tamil Tigers to end a long-running civil war.